# Catholic Morality: Chapters 4 & 5 cram sheet

Jesus as Moral Guide and Conscience Formation. Test: 50 questions (multiple choice, true/false, matching) plus one essay of about 7 to 8 sentences.

## The eight Beatitudes

| Blessed are... | for they... |
|---|---|
| 1. the poor in spirit (**anawim**) | theirs is the kingdom of heaven |
| 2. they who mourn | will be comforted |
| 3. the meek (not weak; right use of anger) | will inherit the land |
| 4. they who hunger and thirst for righteousness | will be satisfied |
| 5. the merciful (empathy, forgive) | will be shown mercy |
| 6. the clean of heart (see as God sees) | will see God |
| 7. the peacemakers (**shalom**) | will be called children of God |
| 8. they who are persecuted for righteousness | theirs is the kingdom of heaven |

- **Beatitude** = supreme happiness. Taught at the start of the **Sermon on the Mount** (Matthew 5 to 7). They call you to embrace the Kingdom of God, the vision of God, the joy of the Lord, God's rest.
- **Beatific Vision**: contemplation of God in heavenly glory. The Kingdom has a present dimension: be salt and light now.

## Jesus, the moral norm

- Moral norm because he is **God incarnate**, human and divine; he redeemed, sanctified, justified us. Qualities: compassionate, truthful, accepted all, treated women and men equally, sensitive to children, prayerful.
- **Kingdom of God**: God reconciling and renewing all things; begun in Jesus, completed at the end of time; peace, justice, love.
- **Repentance** (metanoia): sorry in heart, mind, will; resolve not to sin. Faith + grace.
- **Great Commandment**: love God with all your heart, soul, mind; love neighbor as yourself.
- **Corporal works of mercy**: feed the hungry, give drink to the thirsty, clothe the naked, shelter the homeless, visit the sick, visit the imprisoned, bury the dead.

## Old Law to New Law

| Old Law | New Law |
|---|---|
| Do not kill | Control anger; reconcile |
| No adultery | No lust in the heart |
| Bill of divorce | Marriage is lifelong |
| No false oaths | Yes means yes (integrity) |
| Eye for an eye | Turn the other cheek |
| Hate your enemy | Love your enemies |

- Jesus fulfills, not abolishes: **spirit over the letter**, a law of love. Matthew 6: clean heart, pure intentions, trust in God; almsgiving, prayer, fasting done humbly.
- **Golden Rule**: do to others whatever you would have them do to you. Closing rules: narrow gate; pray with trust; build on Christ's words. Own-words prayer = **spontaneous prayer**.

## Virtues, gifts, fruits

- **Cardinal** (cardo = hinge; gained by effort): prudence (applies principles), justice (gives due), fortitude (courage), temperance (moderation).
- **Theological** (infused by God): faith, hope, charity (the greatest; agape = selfless love).
- Against faith: incredulity, **heresy** (deny a truth), **apostasy** (reject Christ totally), **schism** (refuse the pope). Against hope: despair, presumption. Against charity: indifference, ingratitude, lukewarmness, hatred.
- **7 gifts**: wisdom, understanding, counsel, fortitude, knowledge, piety, fear of the Lord. **12 fruits**: charity, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, generosity, gentleness, faithfulness, modesty, self-control, chastity.
- **Character**: your response to God's invitation to love. Good character: loving, fully human, virtuous. **Sacramental character**: indelible mark of Baptism, Confirmation, Holy Orders.

## Discipleship

- **Priest**: offer daily life as sacrifice. **Prophet**: proclaim Christ. **King**: self-mastery, justice, service. Begins at Baptism; Confirmation strengthens.
- **Evangelical counsels**: poverty, chastity, obedience. Contemplative orders pray (Benedictines); apostolic orders serve (Jesuits); hermits withdraw; societies of apostolic life pledge without vows (Maryknolls). The **laity** are not ordained.

## Conscience

- **Conscience**: a practical judgment of reason about the goodness or evil of an act; form it, then follow it. Where you are alone with God.
- **NOT**: majority opinion, a feeling, the superego (Freud), a gut instinct, Jiminy Cricket, just guilt.
- **IS** (Vatican II): law written on the heart; summons to good; binding; inner sanctuary; reveals divine law of love.
- 3 aspects: relationship with God, awareness of God's call to love, practical judgment of the intellect. 4 tasks: urge good, keep from evil, guide, judge past acts.
- 2 principles: always form and inform it; always obey your **certain** conscience.
- **SEER**: Study the facts, Elect (with prayer), **Execute** (the true test), Review. A seer is a prophet.
- **Examination of conscience**: honest, prayerful assessment of how well you lived God's covenant of love; for the Sacrament of Penance.

## Erroneous judgment

| Invincible ignorance | Vincible ignorance |
|---|---|
| Cannot be overcome; NOT culpable (the act is still evil) | Could be overcome; culpable (cared little for truth) |

- Uncertain conscience: get more formation. Habitual sin makes conscience "sightless." Also: ignorance of Christ, bad example, passions, false autonomy, rejecting the Church, no repentance, no love.
- **Primacy of conscience** = no one may force you against it. **God's law** is the final judge, not individual conscience.

## Peer pressure and fortitude

- Neutral (fads), positive (inspires good), negative (pushes wrong; "Everyone is doing it").
- Strategies: know your standards; learn to say no; avoid tempting situations; pray.
- **Fortitude**: firmness in difficulties; grown by self-denial, prayer, service; ultimate act is **martyrdom**. Offering up builds it.

**Key**: CCC = Catechism of the Catholic Church; SEER = Study, Elect, Execute, Review.